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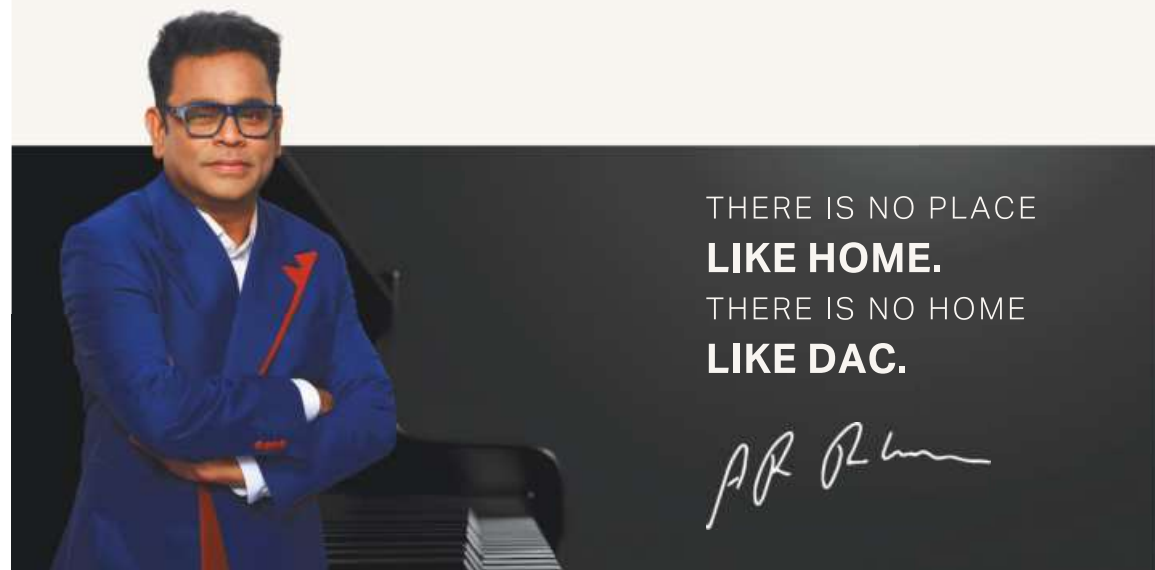
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New defence college in Avadi

The Ground Defence College of the Indian Air Force would serve as a training institute

Think Avadi and defence comes to your mind. A new college is now going to deepen that association.

The Indian Air Force Ground Defence College was inaugurated at the Air Force Station Avadi by Air Marshal S. Sivakumar, Air Officer-in-charge Administration on September 7, 2026.

This college promises to be a step towards strengthening specialised security and airbase ground defence training in the defence sector.

The inauguration of the insti-



From the inaugural event. PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

tution marks an important milestone in enhancing the preparedness and operational effectiveness of IAF personnel entrusted with ground defence and security of the airbases, said a press release. The first Ground Combat Course has also commenced at the newly established facility. The Ground Defence College will impart specialised training to air force personnel on ground combat and other security elements. It has personnel from different ranks who will be getting trained.

The inaugural event was attended by representatives from the IAF Headquarters Maintenance Command, IAF Training Command and invitees from the Defence Forces and civil security agencies, added the release.

College at Pattabiram gets autonomous status



Dharmamurthi Rao Bahadur Calavala Cunnan Chetty's Hindu College, Pattabiram, is now an autonomous institution. According to a press release, the college celebrated its new status and significant milestone by organising an event in which Dr. Sathyanarayana N. Gummadi, Professor, Indian Institute of Technology - Madras, was the chief guest.

In his address, he highlighted the competitive edge offered by autonomy. He also emphasised the role of teachers in nation-building. The college authorities – N. Rajendra Naidu, director; G. Kalvikkarasi, principal; and M. Venkatesaperumal, honorary secretary were present on the occasion, adds the press release.

READERS WRITE

'Recurrent sewage problem'

Sewage overflow has become a recurrent issue at Nehru Bazaar near New Military Road in Avadi. Being a market, this place witnesses vehicular and pedestrian movement, but is kept unhygienic. Despite repeated complaints to the Avadi Corporation, remedial measures have not been taken.

T. Sadagopan, president, Tamil Nadu Progressive Consumer Centre, Avadi

Nehru Bazaar in Avadi. PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



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‘Vacant plots pose a threat’

Snakes are spotted often and water stagnation raises the risk of vector-borne diseases

NASSER NISSAR MOHAMMED

Vacant plots along Francis Colony Second Main Road in Madhavaram are being misused to dump debris, clothes, and all other kinds of waste including sanitary waste.

Residents in the vicinity have to endure the poor sanitation marked by stench and flyblown waste pile ups.

Further, these parcels of land are overrun with vegetation providing a conducive environment for snakes. They enter nearby houses.

In the latest instance, which occurred last week, two snakes were spotted. A month ago, a big snake was spotted. The services of Tamil Nadu Fire & Rescue Services had to be availed.

Snakes are found in good num-

bers because frogs are in abundance here.

The problem gets aggravated during the rainy season.

Water could be found stagnant in commodes.

This gives room for outbreak of vector-borne diseases.

All these pose a serious health and safety hazard. Residents are unable to keep their windows and doors open.

Several complaints to Greater Chennai Corporation have been in vain.

Nasser Nissar Mohammed is a resident of Madhavaram

An unkempt parcel of land at Francis Colony in Madhavaram.

PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



The park at 37th Street on SIDCO Nagar Fourth Main Road in Villivakkam. PHOTO: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

‘Lock this park at night’

M. SENTHIL

Street lamps at the Greater Chennai Corporation's children's park at 37th Street on SIDCO Nagar Fourth Main Road in Villivakkam that were non-functional for the past three years were set right recently after several complaints.

Another issue plaguing the park is that it is kept open during night hours. This gives room for alcohol consumption and other unlawful activities during night. Greater Chennai Corporation should display a board announcing the park time and should lock it at other hours.

Adolescent boys misuse the park to play cricket. The recreational space is meant for younger children. GCC should look into the issue. Visitors also see the need for a few more play equipment.

This park falls under Ward 94 in Zone 8 Anna Nagar of the Greater Chennai Corporation.

M. Senthil is a resident of Villivakkam

‘More CCTV cameras needed at Ambattur railway station’

T. GUNASEELAN

Southern Railway installed CCTV cameras at Ambattur railway station recently. This move towards enhancing the safety and security of the station is obviously welcome.

But they have been installed only at the foot overbridge and at platform one where EMU trains toward Avadi and Thiruvallur are handled.

I request the authorities to install the surveillance cameras on platform two and three too. In the case of platform three, fast local EMU trains and a few express trains including Yelagiri Express halt and EMU trains toward Chennai Central are handled at platform two.

Likewise, CCTV cameras should be installed on the approach roads to the station. There is one near the station's entrance on GNG Third Street in Varadharajapuram. This spot is poorly lit. Here, a high mast lamp is needed so that the quality of the camera footage is clear and visible.

Besides, a few more CCTV cameras are needed, especially around the markets near the station as they are always crowded. These areas do not come under the purview of the Southern Railway. Hence, either the Greater Chennai Corporation or the police should do the needful.

T. Gunaseelan is a resident of Ambattur



The recently installed CCTV cameras at Ambattur railway station. PHOTOS: SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



LAKSHMY HARIKRISHNAN

S ydenhams Road in Periamet is the “wardrobe” for blue collar workers. On this oft-crowded thoroughfare, from the point where the Greater Chennai Corporation’s headquarters (Ripon Building) begins to the point where the Nehru stadium almost ends, around thirty shops, some found in a cluster and others spaced apart, provide passersby with a peek into this wardrobe.

There is something for almost every front-line worker under the sun. Uniform for security personnel; safety jackets for those working amidst traffic; safety helmets for construction workers; gear tailored for house keeping staff and conservancy workers; shoes, boots, caps and belts associated with the police force; general caps; and laboratory coats. Do not let that “and” hoodwink the reader into thinking this list is exhaustive. It hardly is. Bulk orders placed by corporates government agencies, education institutions and construction companies among others as well as individual purchases sustain this business. And for novelty, orders sometimes fly in from cricket leagues and franchises.

This visual side to Sydenhams Road is familiar for old timers; and it remains its dominant feature. For the superficial eye, little has changed. Can that be said about the eye that has been taking in this “scenery”, day in day out, for years, and even decades? Has anything in the market shifted significantly? As it was established in 1945, United Uniform is probably at an advantage while taking that question. It operates from a shop built into the historic Periamet mosque, established in 1838 by hides and skins traders. After Independence, the mosque would go

‘Safety gear is now the major grosser’

Sydenhams Road, dubbed “the Blue Collar Uniform Hub of Chennai”, supports a section of the unorganised sector that only continues to thrive and grow bigger due to a variety of intrinsic factors



through two reconstruction exercises, and that would give birth to these shops, partly defining the lower reaches of the mosque on one side. Kahifullah Khan, the third generation owner of United Uniform, observes this shop was constructed in 1956. At that time, United Uniform was functioning from what was called ‘Red Building’ in Moore Market with the foun-

der and Kahifullah’s grandfather, Hafizullah Khan at the helm. Kahifullah recalls that the enterprise shifted to its current location in the early 1980s following the much-discussed Moore Market fire, an event that led to the scattering of Moore Market traders dealing in various goods to the nooks and crannies of Madras.

On the question of changes, Ka-

Sydenhams Road and an old unorganised business that is still going strong.



hifullah draws attention to the facade of his shop and those of others in the mosque complex. These shops are noticeably below road level, even coming across as basement shops. With a barely concealed chuckle, he remarks that these shops were once above road level; successive road-laying exercises have got them where they are. In every other aspect, according to him, these small enterprises constituting a segment of the unauthorised sector have been on an upward trajectory.

“There are now more shops in this line of business than ever before,” states Kahifullah, adding the changes have had to do with the major buyers’ mindset, and thankfully, meeting those new expectations is hardly a tough ask.

On the dominant category sold by these shops through the decades, Kahifullah points out that in the 1980s, the focus was largely on police-related products and then a shift happened, greater attention now being accorded to medical items, the coats, then NCC and Scouts uniform and accessories. From the 2010s, safety gear is the major grosser: safety shoes, jackets and helmets easily constitute the highest selling category, he states. Yet another noticeable shift has to do with the choice of material for the making of shoes. Around 15 to 17 years ago, the scales tipped in favour of rexine over leather. And Kahifullah believes this change has been driven primarily by “large-scale manufacturing of rexine in Gujarat and Haryana. Some people even import rexine from Korea and China.”

If one parsed through the resilience of these shops, one factor emerges strongly, a bond that goes beyond a common trade. Kahifullah puts a ballpark number on the shops in this line of business on Sydenhams road, thirty-five, and adds that out of that, around 90 percent of them are run by those

that are part of his extended family. He admits there is competitive pricing, but there is also cooperation. In this climate, sourcing items not in one’s stock from others is possible.

One senses a strong sense of connection and continuity best epitomised by Kahifullah himself. He is essentially a techie, having had a long stint in the IT industry, and he peeled himself from it to keep a family legacy going. He joined this business four years ago following his father Shafifullah’s death in 2022.

The narrative about connections and continuity gains greater ground as more conversations are initiated with these tradespeople. At Khaleel Cap Mart, a misnomer as they sell uniform and accessories in addition to caps, Quraishi, 45, who first came to the shop at age 12, during his school days, remarks that the

name ‘Cap Mart’ is a reminder of those early years. The shop originally specialised in caps, from turbans and Muslim prayer caps or Kufis, to Kashmiri caps. As customer requirements changed. So did the shop’s inventory. One of the shop’s most distinctive products is not necessarily the most conspicuous. Its cotton mosquito nets are made in the traditional way and remain popular among police personnel at various police residential quarters. Depending on the bed type, they cost between ₹500 and ₹1,500. Started by Khaleel Ur Rahman, the shop is now run by Quraishi and his brother Nayeem. Quraishi echoes Kahifullah’s sentiment that this business is on an even keel.

Speaking for the tradespeople in his line of business on Sydenhams Road, Quraishi observes digital buying has left no dent in their business. “Individuals might buy a cap online; for bulk orders, they come to us.”

Old Markets, New Trends

This column features markets that have continued to retain their hold on people’s mind space despite the shifting sands of fads. Through entities that have been around for a long time, it seeks to find out what makes these markets tick

G. SOORIYAMOORTHY
AT WORK

The nuts and bolts of creativity

SHARON JESSICA MICHAEL

At first glance, it resembles a pile of wires. On closer look, the contours of a face become evident. That is the idea behind G. Sooriyamoorthy's "The Imaginative Metal Wire Portrait of an Artist", one of two sculptures he is preparing for Auras Elemental, an art show where he will stage his experiments with unconventional materials and painstaking techniques spanning 26 years. His second work, "Within the Armour", engaged with a different material and manages a distinct effect: nuts and bolts assembled into the form of a warrior.

The works might differ in appearance, but both reflect Sooriyamoorthy's preference for materials that demand time, precision and physical effort.

"People ask me why I am using

Sculptor G. Sooriyamoorthy promotes the idea of "art made difficult"; and there is a method to this madness. His works will be on display at Lalit Kala Akademi from October 10 to 15

metal wire when it is so time-consuming," he says. His welding shop is in Tambaram, requiring him to travel back and forth from his home in Ayanavaram as he works on the sculptures. "People ask why I put in so much effort when there are easier ways of creating art. For me, the effort is part of the process."

To reach its final form, the wire

portrait consumed three months. The idea came from drawing: Sooriyamoorthy imagined a face made up of multiple lines, with each wire functioning like a line on paper. Instead of lying flat, however, the lines intersect and move through space, gradually forming the figure.

The process involved little machinery. Using cutting pliers, he cut, stretched and tightened the wires before weaving them together. Continuous work for even 30 minutes to an hour could leave his hands hurting. The ponytail was particularly demanding, with individual wires cut to different lengths and shaped by hand. "No large machines were used," he says. A small skull-like structure sits at the centre of the composition, helping hold the interwoven wires together. The construction, which resembles basket-making, gives the sculpture stability despite the thin material. The metal was also treated to achieve an antique finish.

His second sculpture began with a different challenge. Sooriyamoorthy had been looking for an opportunity to experiment with nuts and bolts when he conceived the idea of a warrior. But before he could begin welding, he had to work out the figure itself. He first made a clay model, shaping and carving the anatomy while leaving spaces for the nuts and bolts to fit. The model was then used to make a plaster of Paris mold.

The choice of plaster was practical. Welding generates considerable heat, and Sooriyamoorthy says plaster of Paris absorbs the heat and helps keep the metal cool. Fibre, another material that is generally used for larger sculptures, could pose a fire risk under welding conditions. The nuts and bolts were welded from inside the sculpture. For the warrior's hair, he used 8 mm metal rods, bending and shaping them before welding them into place. The clay model was started around four months ago, while the welding took four days.

"I was able to finish it in a short

An eclectic mix of artists

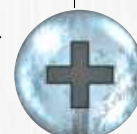
Auras Elemental, an art exhibition featuring artists at different stages of their creative journeys, will be held from 10 to 15 October 2026 at Lalit Kala Akademi, Thousand Lights. The exhibition, which will be inaugurated on October 9, at 5.30 p.m., brings together emerging artists, first-time exhibitors, passionate learners and experienced professionals, creating a space for diverse artistic practices and perspectives.

The title Auras Elemental reflects the exhibition's focus on the energy and presence surrounding artworks and the raw, instinctive nature of creativity. "Auras" refers to the subtle energies associated with each work, while "Elemental" represents creativity in its pure and unrefined form. The exhibition explores how artistic expression takes shape through instinct, intuition and creative impulse.

Bringing together painters, sculptors, visual artists, designers, art educators, installation artists, digital artists and practitioners from various disciplines, the exhibition presents a range of mediums, approaches and artistic journeys.

span of time because I made sure the clay model was perfect in shape. This allowed me to easily weld the nuts and bolts according to my requirements," he says.

The contrast between the two sculptures also points to Sooriyamoorthy's larger approach to materials. Stone remains his favourite, largely because of the difficulty involved in working with it. Fibre is comparatively easier, he says, while metal and stone require greater time and effort. That difficulty, rather than convenience, appears to be what keeps him experimenting. As he gets the two sculptures ready for Auras Elemental, the material is as much a part of the work as the form it eventually takes.



Social media opening doors to child marriages?

On September 4, 2026, the United Nations General Assembly declared November 27 as the International Day for the Elimination of Child, Early and Forced Marriage. Child rights activists in Chennai weigh in on what it takes, particularly in the online space, to counter the evil of child marriage

LIFY THOMAS

Last year, the District Child Welfare Committee in Chennai dealt with a case where a 15-year-old girl from Nepal had married a 28-year-old man working in Chennai, the two having met on Instagram. With the help of friends, they got married in Chennai.

A month into the marriage, the girl was traced after she made a call to her sister in Nepal. The girl's family lodged a complaint with the police following which India Child Protection, a civil society organisation working in the area of child protection, intervened to rescue the girl.

Social media and online dating are increasingly exposing vulnerable girls to greater risk of child marriage.

"With advancement in digital communication, the *modus operandi* in child marriage is changing, making more children vulnerable," says Bhuwan Ribhu, a child rights activist and founder of Just Rights for Children.

Bhuwan Ribhu says trafficking is a borderless crime, and it requires a borderless response. Online methods of enticement or grooming for marriage, sexual abuse and trafficking have become possible irrespective of distance and geography.

In a study taken by NGO Save the Children, they observed that girls in India faced greater online risk of child marriage and trafficking during the pandemic. The agency continues to work with children and teachers to raise awareness about staying safe online.

According to the National Family Health Survey (2019-21), the national average in India for child marriage is 23%. The prevalence rate in India for child marriage has fallen by 10 per cent. The Bal Vivah Mukta Bharat campaign launched by the Central Government in November 2024 promises to make India child marriage-free by 2030 and is seeing various state governments running different initiatives.

A dedicated CMPO needed

Natharsha Malim H, state coordinator - Tamil Nadu, India Child Protection, says while Tamil Nadu has been making steady progress in reporting and stopping child marriages, gaps continue to exist.

Tamil Nadu, he says, does not have Child Marriage Prohibition Officers (CMPOs) that are appointed to prevent marriages, gather evidence, raise awareness and report data. The District Social Welfare Officer (DSWO) is notified as the Child Marriage Prohibition Officer of the concerned district.

ILLUSTRATION: SREEJITH R KUMAR

"This is an additional role that the DSWO takes up. We have been asking for a dedicated person to be appointed as many other states have done based on a Supreme Court recommendation," says Malim.

For example, in Karnataka, the Department of Women and Child Welfare has included pre-university (PU) college principals as child marriage prohibition officers, whose responsibility is to prevent any girl child



studying in their college from marrying before 18 years.

Dedicated officials tasked with curbing this practice is particularly required in places such as Salem, Dindigul, Namakal and Cuddalore which has reported maximum cases of child marriages, says Malim. Grama panchayats have to be empowered in these districts to curb child marriage

A rule book for intervention

Malim notes that State Governments have to draw up a Standard Operating Procedure (SOP) for elimination of child marriages.

"The Supreme Court came out with a landmark judgement on child marriages in October 2024, but Tamil Nadu is yet to come out with an SOP," he says.

Panchayats that make an earnest effort to stop child marriage should be rewarded; and the bravery of young girls that resist coercion by family into child marriage should also be acknowledged.

Bhuwan Ribhu cites the example of a study done by India Child Protection in 2025, wherein cases in Assam dropped by 84 percent following a continuous crackdown by law-enforcement authorities.

Although Prohibition of Child Marriage Act, 2006 has been in existence for decades, enforcement leaves a lot to be desired.

"With amendments to the law and judgments by the Supreme Court, we have been able to see much impact on the ground, along with greater awareness," says Ribhu, adding, "awareness needs to be supplemented with the enforcement of policies, accountability of institutions, and the use of technology for monitoring."

How to report a child marriage

File a complaint with

Child Marriage Prohibition Officer

District Magistrate Nearest police station

District Child Protection Unit

ASHA Unit of District Legal Services Authority

Bal Vivah Mukta Bharat portal <https://stopchildmarriage.wcd.gov.in>

Source: Ministry of Women and Child Development

Residents association in Chennai hails UN declaration



On September 4, 2026, when the United Nations General Assembly declared November 27 as the International Day for the Elimination of Child, Early and Forced Marriage, a residents group in Anna Nagar celebrated the announcement.

A small number of residents, close to 150, of Kambar Colony in Anna Nagar gathered at the park in the neighbourhood to watch the live proceedings of the United Nations General Assembly on the designation of November 27 as the International Day for the Elimination of Child, Early and Forced Marriage.

The programme was organised by the ICWO Tamil Nadu and Kambar Colony Welfare Association. The designation is a significant global commitment to strengthening awareness, prevention and action against child, early and forced marriage. This is a victory for children and civil society organisation that have been fighting to end child marriage.

Awareness banners and charts were displayed, and the gathering concluded with an oath-taking ceremony to strengthen the community's commitment to end child marriage.

ICWO is a partner agency with Just Rights with Children in Chennai, working with educational institutions and communities on rights concerning children.

A.J. Hariharan, founder secretary, ICWO, says reporting is the key to preventing child marriage. He notes: "we work closely with schools and colleges to help eradicate child marriage. All what we ask them is report any cases of child marriage to the helpline number or a teacher."

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Cultural events mark Gokulashtami celebration

Various cultural events marked Gokulashtami celebration at Dwaraka Doss Goverdhan Doss Vaishnav College, Arumbakkam.

According to a press release, the event called "Radhike Rasa" was organised by Srinath Fine Arts, a unit of Vallabh Cultural Academy.

One of the highlights of the event was "Shuk Shari Samvad," a Bengal folklore presentation.

Capt. S. Santhosh Baboo, principal, welcomed the gathering and noted that the students had practised two months for the programme.

Harikatha exponent, Dushyanth Sridhar, was the chief guest. A book on Lord Tirupati Balaji was presented to him on the occasion. In his address, Dushyanth Sridhar delved on the life and teachings of Lord Krishna, adds the press release.

Velammal Nexus honours teachers with awards



Velammal Nexus felicitated its teachers with service awards and academic excellence awards for their outstanding contributions.

To mark their commitment and achievements, the school

presented prizes worth ₹70 lakh.

Correspondent M. V. M. Velmohan handed over the cheque to the senior in-charges representing all Velammal Nexus schools on behalf of the awardees.



Conference on green chemistry held

A two-day national conference on 'New Trends in Green Chemistry and Sustainable Environment' was held recently at the BSA Crescent Institute of Science and Technology in Vandalur.

Sponsored by the Anusandhan National Research Foundation (ANRF) and the Tamil Nadu State Council for Science and Technology (TNSCST), the event brought top scientists, researchers, and green-tech industry experts to tackle growing climate and environmental challenges.

The conference focused on creating a cleaner future.

Key topics discussed included eco-friendly chemical manufacturing, reducing hazardous waste, recycling advancements, and sustainable materials designed to support green energy.

Experts noted that while public demand for eco-friendly products is at an all-time high, scientists must invent newer, safer chemical processes to build a fully circular economy.

Academic scholars presented major research papers detailing new developments. These included eco-friendly food packaging made from biodegradable plants, advanced nanotechnology to clean polluted water systems, leather processing, waste-to-value-added products, and green energy conversion and storage.

Wildlife photography contest

The Rotary Club of Chennai Crown, in partnership with Madras Photobloggers, is organising 'Yaavarum 2026', a contest for the speech and hearing impaired.

The contest aims to promote wildlife protection through nature conservation and encourage participants to explore, observe, and capture the beauty and importance of the natural world through their own lens.

The contest is open to first-time photographers.

Entries will be accepted till September 30. Each participant may submit up to three photographs, taken with either a mobile phone or a camera. However, AI-generated images will not be permitted.

Winners will be honoured during 'Wildlife Week 2026' in October. The public is requested to share information about the contest with deaf and hard-of-hearing friends, communities, networks, colleges, and institutions for deaf students.

For registration, log on to <https://forms.gle/btUHUV-DYd26UgZpi8>, a press release said.

Special sweet boxes for Ganesh Chaturthi

Sri Krishna Sweets is bringing special sweets and savouries boxes for Ganesh Chaturthi. Each box includes mysurpa, laddu, sweet kozhukattai, adhirasam, sweet seva, aval mixture, milagu thattai and kara kozhukattai.

With this box, one will receive a Vinayagar clay statue and prasadam. The special boxes will be available on September 13 and 14 at all their outlets.

On September 14, hot sweet

and kara kozhukattai will be available in Adyar, Alwarpet, Ambattur, Anna Nagar, Ashok Nagar, Bazullah Road, T.Nagar, Chrompet GST Road, Egmore, Guduvanchery, Iyyapanthangal, Jafferkanpet, Madipakkam, Medavakkam, Mylapore, Nee-lankarai, Porur, Purasaiwak-kam, Sembakkam, Tambaram West, Triplicane, Velachery, and Venkatnarayana Road, T Nagar, outlets from 9 a.m. to 1 p.m. till stocks are available.

Hope for persons with knee osteoarthritis

Kamakshi Memorial Hospitals has started a "knee-preservation-first approach" to treat advanced osteoarthritis.

Dr. Deepak Kumar K S, an orthopaedic surgeon and a knee replacement and Mako Stryker expert, carefully evaluates every patient and explores appropriate treatment options to preserve the natural knee before considering replacement surgery, said a press release. Dr. Deepak has collaborated with Dr. Sathish Kumar Thangamani, a senior assistant professor at Stanley Medical College and consultant at Dr. Kamakshi Memorial Hospitals, to administer allogeneic bone marrow-derived mesenchymal stem cell therapy for select patients with knee osteoarthritis.



Dr. Deepak Kumar

In a release, Dr Deepak says, "Wherever clinically appropriate, I believe in exploring every possible avenue to preserve the patient's natural knee."

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